



### The marsupial mole – a report

The Aboriginal name for the marsupial mole varies according to the locality in which it is found. In central western Australia it is referred to as 'the blind sand burrower', *Arra-jarra-ja*, or *Kakarratul* for the northern species and *Itjaritjari* for the southern species. Elsewhere in the southern Northern Territory, it is known as *Oorquamata*.

The marsupial mole looks like a mole or a small solid rat. It has a pouch like other marsupials, measures about 10 – 20 cm and weighs 40 – 60 g. It has soft, fine fur of a cream-yellow colour. It has no external sign of eyes, although there are eye spots hidden under the skin. There is also no sign of external ears, but there are distinct ear openings beneath the fur. The nose is a small shield of horny skin used for pushing the sand away to make a tunnel. The nostrils are small slits. The short tail, only about 2 cm long, is encircled with rings and terminates in a tough lump. The limbs are short and powerful, each foot having five digits. The third and fourth fingers are large and scoop-like, with sharp claws for digging. The pouch opens toward the rear so that sand is not pushed into it.

The marsupial mole is believed not to drink, although it must eat food every day. It seems to reproduce during early summer, but no details are known about its breeding.

**1** a Read the report on the marsupial mole and sketch what you think it looks like.

b Suggest why scientists do not know about the reproduction of the marsupial mole.

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c Predict what a marsupial mole would eat, and how it would find this food.

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d Explain how scientists might have learnt that the marsupial mole does not drink.

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# Design an animal



**2** Imagine this environment: It is deep in the ocean, there is only faint reddish light. The floor is covered with large jagged boulders rising up from the sandy ground like mountains.

- a Design a plant that might grow there. Sketch the plant and explain the purpose of some of its adaptations.

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- b Design an animal that might live in the same environment. Sketch it and explain the purpose of some of its adaptations.

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- c You are a scientist asked to explore this ocean environment. Sketch yourself fitted out and explain the purpose of your clothing and equipment.

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